

A Talk for Association of Retired Persons
Bellville, Texas Aug. 3, 1983

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I'm here today to tell you something about the
Austin County Historical Commission.

What it is. What it does What it's supposed
to do.

As all of you are aware we live in a state
that is rich in history and legend. Texas is
a state that occupies an area which was originally
explored by the Spanish and later the French.

Before they came, however, we know the Indians
were here, Apaches, Comanches, Kiowas,
Karankawas, Caddoes, Boskettes, Bedias.

All these tribes lived in various parts of
Texas. There was one tribe which was a
branch of the Caddo — their name Tejas which
meant "friend" was what the Spanish called
this area. And that is how our state got its
name. Coronado originally explored Texas starting
in 1540.

He came here for one purpose only. GOLD
for the Spanish treasury.

The French came then in 1658 when La Salle
established his colony at Matagorda.

There was very little change in Texas during
the 1700's. — the Spanish and Indians were the
primary occupants.

In the 1800's however anglos and immigrants from other countries began to come to Texas. These years saw people from Germany, Poland, France, Russia, Bohemia, Slovakia and other countries come into the area. Texas became a giant crucible or melting pot of many ethnic groups.

The spanish gave land grants to people just to come in and settle the land.

The result was a broad, vast area occupied by many different nationalities, all of whom had their own culture.

These people had to be strong and full of courage because they faced many hardships - horrible weather, Indians, disease, starvation. Anything to discourage the fainthearted was here in those days.

But they stayed, they struggled, they survived and they died, leaving behind remnants of their culture - their legends - and their descendants.

Texas became a republic in 1836, and joined the union in 1845.

Texas was in the Confederacy 1861-1865

All of this background I've been giving you is to help you to realize that Texas has had a history as romantic, and colorful, and varied as any area in the United States.

With this kind of a background the people of Texas finally realized that something needed to be done to preserve their historical past. This meant not only documents and artifacts but our visual history - the things we can see - historic sites - and buildings and homes.

The Texas Centennial in 1936 was the beginning of a conscious effort to have publicly sponsored preservation activity. In 1953 the Texas Historical Commission was established by act of the State Legislature. Originally its duties were to survey and list historical sites and buildings. Eventually its responsibilities broadened over the years and it now serves as the principal guide and clearing house for all preservation activity on a state and local level.

The state legislature also established a county historical commission for each of its counties. These county historical commissions are a part of the county government. They are an official body, appointed by the county judge for a 2 year term. They vary in size but the average is about 15 members who are selected from the various areas of each county.

A county historical commission is obligated by law to hold at least one meeting each year.

The Austin County Historical Commission meets once each month - 12 times a year.

Our meetings are open to the public as we are governed by the OPEN MEETINGS ACT.

We meet @ 7:30 p.m. the first Tuesday of the month.

WHAT DO WE DO?

The commission has several areas of responsibility

HISTORIC RESEARCH

oral interviews, photographic archives

HISTORICAL MARKERS PROGRAM.

assist applicants

approval of applications

arrange ceremonies for marked dedications

maintain files on historical markers in county

MUSEUMS

HISTORIC PRESERVATION

to educate the public on the advantages of preservation

National Register Programs

Tax incentives

15% 30 years

20% 40 years

100% historic property 15/85

ARCHEOLOGICAL PROJECTS

LAND HERITAGE REGISTRY

A special project which our commission has undertaken is a census of all burial sites in Austin County.

This is a tremendous task since there are at least 75 known cemeteries in Austin County both public and private. We have been working on this for over 2 years and we still have a long way to go. We survey each cemetery of family plot grave by grave, recording the persons name date of birth and date of death.

When completed, we will have an alphabetical listing by cemetery, and also an alphabetical listing for the entire county. We hope to eventually have all this data in a computer as part of our county records. Then anyone trying to trace their ancestry or locate their great grandmother's grave will be able to come to us and we can give them what they need. If a grave is marked (and readable) hopefully will have a record of it.

Another project we are working on now is the Austin County Historical Museum. You're all familiar with the old Austin County Jail. Built in 1896, this magnificent old building has been turned over to the Austin County Historical Commission for conversion into a County Historical Museum.

Austin County is one of the most historic areas of our state. San Felipe - birthplace of Texas named after Stephen F. Austin.

Many of the original 300 colonists lived and died in Austin County. Some are buried here in Bellville. We have a campsite of Santa Ana's army out near Bleiberville. We have the original home of Frederick Ernst, the little German who first started the German colonization in our area at Industry. We have a rich cultural and historic heritage in Austin County - one which needs to be preserved.

The town of Bellville has a unique history. I had a friend from Houston ask me one time if Bellville was named after that bell down there in front of the courthouse!

Most of you know that Bellville was established on land donated by 2 brothers, Thomas and James Bell. In 1822 they had bought a tract of land out of the John Nichols League in Austin's Colony.

These two young men were from Florida and they camped one nite near a beautiful grove of pine trees. This reminded them of their home in Florida.

They liked it so well they decided to stay and start a town!

One of the earliest settlers and the man who built the 1st house was Jim Erwin that was in 1849.

Other early names were Ben Cheek, John Atkinson, J.B. Granville, John Nichols.

A surveyor named Chas. Amthor laid out the town of Bellville in 1848.

1848 was also the year the county seat was moved from San Felipe to Bellville.

First court house a wood frame built in 1848

It was replaced by a brick courthouse in 1854.

In 1866 the 3rd courthouse was built. \$45,000

The old one was torn down by Gus and Henry Louwein for all the material plus a \$100 fee.

The first brick business building was built by W.S. Springfield. It was a drugstore S. side of square

Santa Fe Railroad came to Bellville in 1888,
the old roundhouse was built in 1899.